that occurred between us in the past.

I remember a flare-up involving the then-not-disgraced brilliant paceman Mohammad Asif. We were at Centurion in South Africa, joking around in the dressing room, when things just escalated. Shoaib and I were sitting on the lounge chairs, and Asif was in the washroom, not too far away. Basically, Shoaib and I were having a verbal go at it, like lads usually do, and Asif – who was listening to our witty exchange – was having a laugh at Shoaib's expense.

Now bear in mind that Asif and Shoaib were really close and hunted in pairs, both on and off the field. Maybe that's why Shoaib was more sensitive, as Asif had found one of my jokes funny, not his. Thus, Shoaib lost it, picked up a bat and broke down the bathroom door, and just gave it to Asif. It was an outbreak over nothing except testosterone and boys being boys. But that episode complicated things for both of us over time. He was banned and heavily fined. Still, as captain, I brought him back, tried to put the incident behind us and moved on.

Across the world, across teams, the dressing room has all sorts of players. There are those who suck up to captains and others in power. To get access, to gain favour, to be in the 'inner circle of the skipper', perhaps even to overcome their own shortcomings and failures, these players play a lot of politics, turn the captain against other players, or even make him imagine things. That's the crux of what went wrong with many captains and players in the Pakistan dressing room in the years building up to the spot-fixing scandal.

Although it has been rumoured, I was not a part of this scheming and politics. I'm from an era where I played with big names, legends who had big hearts, and I always sought advice from the seniors while bonding with the juniors. I stood alone and still do. Yes, I had conflicts, but they were openly initiated and openly resolved. I didn't fight cold wars. But the passive-aggressive tension that was building up in the Pakistan team during those years was beyond my control.

Think of it this way. If I say something to you about someone else and I'm your only window of insight about that person, your only source about what they're up to – because for whatever reason you're not directly in touch with them yourself – then you will start forming your opinions about them just through me. If I understand this dynamic, I can use it against that person at will and abuse the access I have to your office. That's what was happening all around me, to all the players.

It was like brother killing brother. It was fratricide.